



DON'T WANT TO, BUT MUST!

M / 1931

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Crime drama

DIRECTOR

Fritz Lang

WRITERS

**Fritz Lang,
Thea von Harbou**

STARS

**Peter Lorre, Otto Wernicke,
Gustaf Gründgens**

BEFORE

1927 *Metropolis*, Lang's seminal science-fiction epic, is groundbreaking for the scale of its futuristic vision.

AFTER

1935 Karl Freund, who was the cinematographer on *Metropolis*, directs *Mad Love*, a Hollywood horror starring the by now famous Peter Lorre.

1963 In the last movie he makes, Lang appears in front of the camera, playing himself in Jean-Luc Godard's *Le mépris* (*Contempt*).

Classic old movies as influential as Fritz Lang's *M*—without which there would have been no *Psycho*, *Silence of the Lambs*, or *Se7en*—can be slightly disappointing when viewers finally come to see them. By then the movies will have been so emulated and borrowed from that they can end up looking somewhat hackneyed. Not so with *M*—Lang's crime masterpiece still bristles with chilling invention.

The real-life crimes of Peter Kürten, known in the press as the Vampire of Düsseldorf, were fresh in the minds of German audiences when *M* was released in May 1931. Lang later denied that Kürten was the inspiration for his script. Although he was clearly tapping into a theme that was sitting high in the public consciousness, his portrayal of a murderer was far from predictable.

The first surprise was in the casting. Little-known Hungarian actor Peter Lorre, a small man with bulging, oddly innocent eyes, seemed an unlikely choice to play a child killer. The next surprise was in the movie's oblique narrative. While concerned with justice, *M* is not a simple tale of crime and punishment, and defies expectations from the outset.

Shots of absence

The movie's opening murder is set up with a heartbreaking poignancy: as Beckert, who is seen only in silhouette, approaches a young girl at a

The movie's iconic poster displays the "M" (for murderer) that will be imprinted on the killer's back so that he can be trailed.

